

SnowyKim New York HR Information Access and Confidentiality Policy

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Policy Owner: Human Resources

Approved By: Director of Human Resources

Applies To: Employees assigned to SnowyKim's New York City, New York office

Document Classification: Internal—Confidential

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1. Purpose

SnowyKim maintains employment-related information to administer payroll, benefits, performance management, workplace accommodations, leave, safety, security, and other legitimate business functions.

This policy establishes:

- Which parties may access different categories of HR information
- The conditions under which access is permitted
- How confidential information must be stored and disclosed
- SnowyKim's process for employee requests concerning their own records
- Requirements for medical and accommodation information
- Procedures for legal, regulatory, and government requests
- Responsibilities for preventing unauthorized access or disclosure

Access to HR information must be based on a legitimate business need. Seniority, technical access, executive status, or personal familiarity with an employee does not independently create a right to view that employee's records.

2. Scope

This policy applies to:

- Regular employees
- Temporary employees
- Managers
- Executives
- Human Resources personnel
- Payroll and Finance personnel
- Benefits administrators

- Information Technology personnel
- Contractors with approved access
- Third-party service providers processing employee information

It applies to information maintained in:

- Human resources information systems
 - Payroll systems
 - Benefits platforms
 - Performance-management systems
 - Leave-management systems
 - Email
 - Shared drives
 - Paper records
 - Case-management tools
 - Security systems
 - Approved company applications
 - System backups and archives
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3. Core Access Principles

3.1 Minimum Necessary Access

Employees and service providers may access only the minimum information reasonably necessary to complete an authorized responsibility.

3.2 Legitimate Business Purpose

Permitted reasons for accessing HR information may include:

- Processing payroll
- Administering benefits
- Managing a direct report
- Reviewing employee performance
- Administering approved leave
- Responding to a legal obligation
- Investigating a workplace concern
- Maintaining an HR system
- Completing an authorized audit
- Protecting company or employee security

Curiosity, gossip, personal interest, retaliation, or informal workplace requests are not legitimate business purposes.

3.3 Separation of Duties

Technical access does not automatically create permission to view or use HR content.

An IT administrator may maintain systems, restore backups, or investigate an application error without receiving general authorization to review employee compensation, medical information, performance reviews, or investigation records.

3.4 Deny by Default

When the requester's authority is unclear, access must be denied or paused until Human Resources or the applicable data owner confirms authorization.

3.5 Individual Accountability

Employees must use their own accounts and credentials. Shared user accounts are prohibited unless specifically approved for an automated service or technical function.

Access may be logged, reviewed, and audited.

4. HR Information Classifications

4.1 General Internal HR Information

Examples include:

- Employee handbook
- General benefits guide
- Holiday calendar
- General leave procedures
- Expense-reimbursement procedures
- Office policies
- Training materials

This information may generally be accessed by all active employees.

4.2 Internal Directory Information

Examples include:

- Employee name
- Company email
- Job title
- Department
- Manager
- Work location

- Company telephone number

Directory information may generally be accessed internally for ordinary business communication.

Home addresses, personal telephone numbers, personal email addresses, birth dates, and emergency contacts are not ordinary directory information.

4.3 Confidential Employment Information

Examples include:

- Compensation
- Bonus and commission information
- Equity information
- Performance reviews
- Disciplinary records
- Promotion recommendations
- Employment-status history
- Attendance records
- Payroll records
- Personnel-file materials
- Manager documentation used for employment decisions

Access is limited to the employee, authorized managers, and personnel with an approved HR, payroll, finance, legal, or compliance responsibility.

4.4 Restricted Personal Information

Examples include:

- Home address
- Personal telephone number
- Personal email
- Date of birth
- Emergency contacts
- Dependent information
- Bank-account information
- Tax information
- Government identification numbers
- Immigration and work-authorization records
- Background-check information

Access is limited to specifically authorized personnel.

4.5 Medical and Accommodation Information

Examples include:

- Medical certifications
- Disability documentation
- Accommodation requests
- Pregnancy-related information
- Leave certifications
- Fitness-for-duty documentation
- Workers' compensation medical records
- Benefits claims containing medical information

Medical and accommodation information must be treated as confidential and, where practical, stored separately from ordinary personnel records.

4.6 Highly Restricted HR Information

Examples include:

- Discrimination or harassment complaints
- Investigation interviews
- Witness statements
- Attorney communications
- Ethics reports
- Whistleblower reports
- Workplace-violence assessments
- Legal-hold materials
- Settlement discussions
- Employee-relations case notes

Access is limited to specifically assigned HR, Legal, Compliance, Security, or executive personnel.

4.7 New York Private Information

For security and incident-response purposes, SnowyKim identifies records containing combinations of personal identifiers, account credentials, financial information, biometric information, or other protected private information as security-sensitive.

SnowyKim will maintain reasonable administrative, technical, and physical safeguards for covered private information as required by applicable New York data-security law.

5. Access Roles

5.1 Employees

Employees may access:

- General HR policies
- Their own basic employee profile
- Their own compensation information
- Their own pay statements
- Their own benefits elections
- Their own leave and PTO information
- Their own completed performance reviews made available by SnowyKim
- Records voluntarily provided by Human Resources
- Records that SnowyKim is legally required to provide

Employees may not access:

- Another employee's compensation
- Another employee's performance records
- Another employee's benefits elections
- Medical information belonging to another individual
- Investigation records
- Confidential witness statements
- Manager-only planning documents
- HR case notes
- Company-wide personnel data

Access to one's own information does not authorize alteration of an official record.

5.2 Managers

Managers may access information concerning current direct reports when needed for legitimate supervisory responsibilities.

Permitted information may include:

- Job title and responsibilities
- Department and reporting relationship
- Work schedule
- Attendance information
- Approved or pending time away from work
- Performance goals
- Completed performance reviews
- Corrective-action records involving that manager
- Training completion
- Compensation-planning information made available through an approved process

Managers ordinarily may not access:

- Medical diagnoses
- Medical certifications
- Detailed accommodation documents
- Benefits claims
- Bank or tax information
- Government identification numbers
- Background-check reports
- HR investigation notes
- Confidential witness statements
- Records concerning employees outside their reporting structure

When a direct report receives an accommodation or protected leave, the manager should ordinarily receive only the operational information needed to administer it, such as approved restrictions, schedule modifications, or leave dates.

5.3 Human Resources Staff

Authorized HR personnel may access information required for assigned responsibilities, including:

- Personnel records
- Compensation information
- Benefits enrollment
- Leave records
- Performance documents
- Employee-relations materials
- Onboarding and separation records
- Work-authorization documentation
- Required reporting information

HR personnel must not review records for personal reasons or outside their assigned responsibilities.

5.4 HR Administrators

Designated HR administrators may receive broader access for:

- HR-system administration
- Policy administration
- Compensation administration
- Employee-relations oversight
- Compliance reporting
- Audit response
- Workforce planning
- Legal-response coordination
- Access-control management

Broad access does not eliminate the requirement for a legitimate business purpose.

5.5 Payroll and Finance

Payroll and Finance personnel may access information required to:

- Calculate and issue wages
- Process deductions
- Administer bonuses or commissions
- Complete tax reporting
- Reconcile payroll
- Process approved reimbursements
- Support authorized financial audits

Permitted data may include:

- Employee name and ID
- Pay rate
- Hours worked
- Payroll deductions
- Bank-payment details
- Tax-withholding elections
- Approved compensation changes

Payroll and Finance personnel ordinarily may not access:

- Medical documentation
- Detailed performance reviews
- Investigation records
- Harassment complaints
- Accommodation narratives
- Benefits claims unrelated to payment or deductions

New York employees must receive a wage statement with each payment of wages containing required information such as gross and net wages, deductions, pay rate, and, where applicable, hours worked.

5.6 Information Technology

IT personnel may access systems and technical information necessary to:

- Provision and remove accounts
- Maintain infrastructure
- Manage authentication
- Investigate security incidents
- Restore records
- Resolve technical errors
- Review system logs
- Enforce retention and access controls

IT personnel may not use technical privileges to inspect HR information unless:

- Access is necessary for an assigned technical task
- The task is appropriately authorized
- Access is limited to the minimum necessary information
- The activity is logged where technically feasible

5.7 Executives

Executives may access:

- Aggregated workforce information
- Organizational-planning information
- Approved compensation reports
- Leadership-succession materials
- Records necessary for a specific employment decision
- Information required for legal, financial, or governance responsibilities

Executive status does not automatically provide unrestricted access to every personnel, medical, payroll, or investigation record.

5.8 Legal Counsel

Authorized internal or external counsel may access information necessary to:

- Provide legal advice
- Respond to litigation
- Conduct or supervise investigations
- Address government inquiries
- Preserve evidence
- Review compliance
- Negotiate or document disputes

Access should be coordinated through authorized Human Resources or executive personnel.

5.9 Third-Party Vendors

Approved vendors may receive employee information only when necessary to perform contracted services.

Examples include:

- Payroll processors
- Benefits administrators
- Insurance providers
- Leave administrators
- Background-check providers
- HR-system providers
- Records-storage providers

Before providing access, SnowyKim should confirm:

- The vendor has an authorized business purpose
- The information is limited to what is necessary
- Appropriate confidentiality and security terms apply
- Vendor access can be terminated when services end
- Security incidents must be reported promptly
- Data deletion or return requirements are documented

6. Access Matrix

Information category	Employee	Direct manager	HR staff	HR admin	Payroll/ Finance	IT admin	Executive
General HR policies	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Internal directory	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Own personnel information	Limited	Own only	Assigned need	Yes	Limited	Technical only	Limited
Full personnel file	Voluntary request process	No	Assigned need	Yes	No	Technical only	Limited
Direct-report performance	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No	Limited
Direct-report compensation	No	Approved processes	Limited	Yes	Yes	No	Limited
Company-wide compensation	No	No	Limited	Yes	Yes	No	Approved reports
Pay statements	Own only	No	Limited	Yes	Yes	Technical only	No
Underlying payroll records	Limited	No	Limited	Yes	Yes	Technical only	Aggregate or approved
Benefits enrollment	Own only	No	Assigned need	Yes	Deduction data only	Technical only	Aggregate only
Medical documentation	Own submissions	Restrictions only	Assigned cases	Yes	No	Technical only	No

Information category	Employee	Direct manager	HR staff	HR admin	Payroll/ Finance	IT admin	Executive
Accommodation records	Own case	Implementation details	Assigned cases	Yes	No	Technical only	No
Investigation records	No	Limited if involved	Assigned cases	Yes	No	Technical only	Limited if assigned
Personal contact details	Own only	Limited business need	Assigned need	Yes	Limited	Technical only	Limited
Tax and banking data	Own only	No	Limited	Yes	Yes	Technical only	No
System access logs	Limited	No	Limited	Limited	No	Yes	Limited
Aggregated workforce reports	No	Department-level	Yes	Yes	Yes	Technical metrics	Yes

“Technical only” means that access may occur while maintaining or securing a system, but the role does not have general authorization to use or disclose the underlying HR content.

7. Employee Requests for Personnel Records

New York law generally does not require a private employer to allow an employee to inspect their entire personnel file. SnowyKim nevertheless provides a limited internal request procedure as a voluntary company practice.

Current employees may submit a written request to Human Resources for copies of selected records concerning their employment.

The request should include:

- Employee name
- Employee ID, if known
- Current contact information
- A reasonable description of the requested information
- Whether inspection or a copy is requested
- The reason clarification is needed, when relevant

SnowyKim may provide records such as:

- Final performance reviews previously communicated to the employee
- Signed policy acknowledgments
- Written disciplinary notices previously issued to the employee

- Documents signed by the employee
- Current job description
- Compensation-change notices
- Training records
- Selected employment-status records

SnowyKim may deny, limit, summarize, or redact a request involving:

- Confidential references
- Investigation notes
- Witness statements
- Attorney-client communications
- Attorney work product
- Security information
- Records concerning another person
- Succession planning
- Internal deliberative materials
- Confidential management planning
- Records subject to legal restrictions
- Materials that could compromise an investigation

This voluntary procedure does not create a contractual right to inspect every record maintained by SnowyKim.

Former employees may request copies of records SnowyKim is legally obligated to provide or that Human Resources determines may appropriately be released.

8. Pay Statements and Payroll Information

Employees may access their own pay statements through the approved payroll system.

Pay statements should contain information required by New York law, which may include:

- Employee name
- Employer name and contact information
- Dates covered by the payment
- Rate or rates of pay
- Basis of pay
- Gross wages
- Deductions
- Allowances, where applicable
- Net wages
- Hours worked, where required

New York employers must maintain payroll records containing required wage-and-hour information.

An employee may contact Payroll to:

- Request a replacement pay statement
- Report an apparent error
- Ask for an explanation of deductions
- Request wage information SnowyKim is required to provide
- Dispute missing or incorrect wages

Payroll information will not be released to a coworker, family member, manager, or other third party solely because that person requests it.

Disclosure to an authorized representative may require written authorization or other legally sufficient documentation.

9. Medical, Leave, and Accommodation Confidentiality

Medical and accommodation information must be:

- Classified as confidential
- Stored separately from ordinary personnel materials where practical
- Accessible only to authorized personnel
- Shared with managers only as necessary to implement an approved restriction, schedule, accommodation, or leave
- Protected from informal workplace discussion
- Transmitted through approved secure methods

Managers may be told that an employee:

- Is approved for leave
- Has a modified schedule
- Has specified work restrictions
- Requires particular equipment
- Cannot perform a specified task
- Is expected to return on a particular date

Managers should ordinarily not receive the employee's diagnosis, complete medical history, treatment details, or unrelated health information.

For New York Paid Prenatal Leave, an employer may not condition use of the leave on disclosure of confidential health information or medical records concerning the prenatal appointment.

Paid Family Leave forms, certifications, and supporting information should be shared only with HR, the applicable insurance carrier or administrator, and others with an authorized need. Employees may submit qualifying family-care information as required by the applicable Paid Family Leave process.

10. Investigation and Complaint Records

Workplace-investigation information is highly restricted.

Access may be provided to:

- Assigned HR personnel
- Assigned investigators
- Legal counsel
- Compliance personnel
- Security personnel when relevant
- Decision-makers with a legitimate need
- Government agencies or courts when legally required

Managers, complainants, respondents, and witnesses may receive only the information necessary to participate in or respond to the matter.

SnowyKim cannot guarantee absolute confidentiality because information may need to be shared to investigate allegations, take corrective action, or comply with legal obligations. Information should nevertheless be limited to individuals with a legitimate need to know.

Personnel files or employment information must not be disclosed as retaliation against an employee for reporting discrimination, harassment, or other protected conduct. New York law specifically prohibits retaliatory release of personnel files in connection with protected complaints.

11. Disclosure to Government Agencies and Courts

SnowyKim may disclose HR information when required or permitted by:

- Subpoena
- Court order
- Warrant
- Government audit
- Regulatory request
- Wage or tax-reporting obligations
- Benefits-administration requirements
- Workers' compensation requirements
- Unemployment proceedings
- A legal duty to report or investigate conduct

Employees receiving a request must not respond independently unless authorized.

Requests must be promptly forwarded to Human Resources and, when appropriate, Legal Counsel.

SnowyKim may verify:

- The requester's identity
- The legal authority supporting the request
- The scope of information requested
- Whether notice to the employee is required or permitted
- Whether redaction, objection, or protective measures are appropriate

Only responsive and authorized information should be disclosed.

12. Disclosure to Family Members and Representatives

SnowyKim will not provide confidential employment information to an employee's:

- Spouse
- Domestic partner
- Parent
- Child
- Friend
- Coworker
- Emergency contact

solely because of that relationship.

Disclosure may occur when:

- The employee provides valid written authorization
- A legally recognized representative presents sufficient authority
- Disclosure is legally required
- Disclosure is necessary during a genuine emergency
- Information is required to administer benefits or another approved service

Disclosure must be limited to the authority and purpose provided.

13. Internal Sharing and Communication

Employees must not transmit confidential HR information through:

- Personal email
- Personal cloud storage
- Unapproved messaging applications
- Public channels
- Broadly accessible collaboration spaces
- Unrestricted shared links

Before sharing information internally, the sender must confirm:

- Recipient identity
- Recipient authority
- Legitimate business purpose
- Minimum information needed
- Appropriate communication method
- Whether additional approval is required

Marking a document “confidential” does not replace proper access controls.

14. Printed and Remote-Work Records

Printed confidential records must:

- Be collected promptly from printers
- Be stored in locked locations
- Not be left in conference rooms or shared areas
- Not be removed from the office without authorization
- Be destroyed through approved secure disposal

Employees working remotely must prevent household members, guests, and unauthorized persons from viewing HR information.

Confidential documents should not be printed at home unless necessary and approved.

15. Corrections to Employee Information

Employees must notify Human Resources when relevant personal information changes, including:

- Legal name
- Home address
- Telephone number
- Emergency contact
- Tax-withholding information
- Beneficiary information
- Work-authorization information, where applicable

Employees who believe a SnowyKim HR record is inaccurate may submit a written correction request.

Human Resources will review the request and may:

- Correct an objectively inaccurate field
- Request supporting documentation
- Add a clarification

- Add an employee statement
 - Preserve the original record for legal, audit, or historical reasons
 - Deny a requested alteration when the existing record accurately reflects the original event or decision
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16. Data Security and Incident Response

SnowyKim will maintain administrative, technical, and physical safeguards appropriate to the nature of employee information it maintains.

Safeguards may include:

- Role-based access
- Multifactor authentication
- Encryption
- Secure backups
- Vendor oversight
- Workforce security training
- Access reviews
- Incident-response procedures
- Secure disposal
- Risk assessments

New York's SHIELD Act requires covered businesses maintaining private information concerning New York residents to develop, implement, and maintain reasonable safeguards.

A suspected HR-data incident must be reported immediately.

Examples include:

- Sending a personnel document to the wrong recipient
- Losing a device containing employee information
- Sharing a payroll spreadsheet through an unrestricted link
- Accessing records without authorization
- Exposing credentials or authentication tokens
- Downloading HR records to a personal device
- Receiving a suspicious request for employee data
- Discovering malware in an HR system
- Misplacing printed medical information

Reports should be directed to:

Human Resources

hr@snowykim-demo.com

Information Security

security@snowykim-demo.com

Employees must not conceal an incident, delete evidence, or conduct an unauthorized investigation.

SnowyKim will assess whether the event requires notice to affected individuals, regulators, law enforcement, consumer-reporting agencies, or other parties under applicable law. New York law contains breach-notification requirements for covered private information.

17. Access Reviews

Human Resources and Information Technology will periodically review:

- Active user accounts
- Assigned access roles
- Administrative privileges
- Manager-reporting relationships
- Vendor access
- Shared drives and folders
- Departed-employee accounts
- Dormant accounts
- Access logs
- Role changes following transfers or promotions

Access must be removed or changed promptly when:

- Employment ends
 - A contractor's engagement ends
 - An employee changes roles
 - A manager no longer supervises an employee
 - An authorized business need ends
 - Access was granted incorrectly
 - A security concern arises
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18. Record Retention and Legal Holds

HR records must be retained according to SnowyKim's approved retention schedule and applicable legal requirements.

Employees must not independently destroy, alter, conceal, or permanently remove HR records.

Routine destruction must stop when information is subject to:

- Litigation

- A legal hold
- An investigation
- An audit
- A government inquiry
- A pending employee dispute
- Another preservation requirement

Duplicate working copies should be securely deleted when no longer needed, provided the official record remains preserved.

19. Prohibited Conduct

The following conduct is prohibited:

- Accessing HR information without a business need
- Searching for coworkers, friends, relatives, or executives out of curiosity
- Sharing compensation information from confidential company systems without authorization
- Disclosing medical records without authority
- Using another employee's account
- Allowing another person to use an authenticated session
- Altering access logs
- Downloading restricted records to personal devices
- Using HR information for retaliation, harassment, discrimination, or personal advantage
- Disclosing investigation information to unauthorized parties
- Retaining records after authorization ends
- Attempting to bypass access controls

Nothing in this policy is intended to prohibit employees from lawfully discussing their own wages, hours, or working conditions or from engaging in other legally protected activity.

Violations may result in access removal, corrective action, termination, contractual remedies, or legal action.

20. Non-Retaliation

SnowyKim prohibits retaliation against an individual who, in good faith:

- Reports a confidentiality concern
- Reports unauthorized access
- Requests records through the company process
- Questions a payroll record
- Participates in an investigation
- Reports a security incident
- Refuses to make an unauthorized disclosure
- Exercises a right protected by law

An unsubstantiated good-faith report is not treated as a knowingly false report.

21. Questions and Escalation

Questions concerning HR-record access should be directed to:

Human Resources

hr@snowykim-demo.com

Security incidents should be directed to:

Information Security

security@snowykim-demo.com

When authorization is uncertain, employees must pause and request guidance before accessing or disclosing information.

22. Policy Administration

Human Resources owns this policy and may issue supporting procedures, access matrices, forms, and retention schedules.

SnowyKim may revise this policy to reflect:

- Legal changes
- Regulatory guidance
- Security requirements
- Organizational changes
- New systems
- Audit findings
- Operational needs

Employees will be notified of material changes as appropriate.

23. Acknowledgment

Employees with access to confidential HR information may be required to acknowledge that they:

- Have read this policy
- Understand their access limitations
- Will use information only for authorized purposes
- Will report suspected incidents

- Understand that access may be monitored
- Will return or securely dispose of records when required

Demonstration disclaimer: SnowyKim, its employees, email addresses, systems, and policies are fictional. This document is intended for HR information-access and retrieval testing. It is not legal advice and should be reviewed by qualified New York employment and privacy counsel before real-world use.